



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
CHICAGO BOOTH

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

When a business school ranks #1 in The Economist and Forbes, and #4 in the FT, many hundreds of MBA hopefuls will apply to the school in the hope of securing their place in one of the world's best business schools. But Chicago Booth is not for everybody. An integral part of a university that is very clearly focused on research, including the free market theory developed by the famous "Chicago School," Booth thrives on a culture of inquiry and innovation. The Admissions Committee is looking for individuals who like to challenge conventional wisdom and thrive in situations where they take the lead in solving problems.

The MBA program sets itself apart by having a total flexibility in its curriculum. The school assumes that a graduate student knows what he or she is looking for in an MBA and enables students to specialize in the areas that will help them pursue their future business life. This philosophy is a driving force of Chicago as a whole, and extends to the faculty, who are left to choose their pedagogical methodology. Chicago Booth is for students who know where they are going, are ready to go a step further in their chosen discipline, and want to be challenged with the theories and ideas of tomorrow.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Finance, Economics, Accounting, Entrepreneurship, Organizational Behavior, Strategy

CLASS of 2020

Number of Applicants: 4,298

MBA Class Size: 591

Admissions Selectivity: 22.9%

Yield: 60.17%

Total Tuition: \$144,000

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Financial Services 31.6%; Consulting 31%; Technology 20.3%; Consumer Products 5.3%

Top Recruiters: McKinsey, Amazon, BCG, Bain, Accenture, Morgan Stanley

Avg. Base Salary: \$129,442

Employment in 3 months: 96.3%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	1	1	3	2	4	4	5	4
Financial Times	6	6	6	6	8	9	6	4
Forbes	-	2	-	6	-	7	-	1
The Economist	1	1	1	1	1	-	1	1
US News	4	6	4	4	2	3	1	3

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 28 yrs

Avg. GMAT: 731

Avg. GPA: 3.6

Int'l Students: 30%

Female Students: 42%

Deadlines for 2019-2020: R1 – Sept. 26, 2019 R2 – Dec. 5, 2019 R3 – April 2, 2020*

***COVID-19 changes** (3/26/20): While its original R3 deadline remains, Booth it is allowing a "one-time extension" and will accept R3 apps for this cycle through May 31. It will also continue to accept test scores through an extended deadline of July 1. Chicago Booth Scholars deadline extended to June 1, allowing applicants until July 1 to submit their exam scores.

Sources: Chicago Booth, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News, MBA50



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ESSAYS 2019-2020

Booth kept both new prompts "that directly address your goals and passions," which debuted in 2018:

1. How will the Booth MBA help you achieve your immediate and long-term post-MBA career goals? (250-word minimum)
2. Chicago Booth immerses you in a choice-rich environment. How have your interests, leadership experiences, and other passions influenced the choices in your life? (250-word minimum)

Is there any unclear information in your application that needs further explanation? If so, please use this section to clarify. (300 word maximum)



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By Julie Ferguson

Julie spent five years at the University of Chicago Booth School of Business, having begun her career in higher education with the Lauder Institute at Wharton. At Chicago Booth, Julie worked as a Senior Associate Director of Admissions. In this role she coordinated admissions and recruiting events across the country, connecting prospective students with current students and alumni; interviewed applicants; and advised the admissions committee.

Tip #1 - When should you apply?

Be strategic about which application deadline you will be pursuing. There are three application rounds (September, January, and April) at Chicago Booth, and, as with many other schools, earlier is not necessarily better. The Booth Admissions Committee knows that it will see great profiles in the first and second round, so the school does not need to fill all the places for consultants, bankers and software engineers in round 1, but will use the wait list with discretion to be able to consider everybody applying in round 2. So you are better off waiting for the 2nd round if that means you will have a more complete, well thought out application, or are able to complete a particularly impressive project, secure a promotion, or provide more examples for your recommender to use. The reality is that there are very few places left by round 3, but even then, the Admissions Committee recognizes that there will be a handful of strong candidates applying in the final round for whom places will be available. But the numbers game works against you at this stage, so plan ahead and shoot for September or January to maximize your chances.

Tip #2 - Highlight your individuality

Every year, hundreds of applications pour in from people with consulting, finance, and accounting backgrounds. Current full-time class statistics show that most students enter the program from a business, economics, and engineering undergraduate background. Chicago Booth looks to create a well- rounded, diverse, and unique class. Make this work in your favor, whether your background is “typical” or not. If you do come from a classic background, tailor your application to highlight what makes you different from everyone else in your industry (perhaps you work as an accountant for a non-profit organization). If, for example, you have a marketing/advertising, education, or social sciences background this will play well into creating a more diverse academic environment for the whole; you will want to emphasize the fact that you will be bringing something unique to the discussion, in and out of the classroom.

Tip #3 - It's not all about “Economics”

There is a common perception that Chicago Booth is the “econ” school. Just like you, Booth does not want to be seen as being good at just one thing. The full-time MBA program provides a flexible curriculum, where students are expected to design their own academic experience. Even if your concentration (your academic interests) lies in economics and the world of finance, you should be well versed on what other academic concentrations are available. Know who the key professors are in each academic department and some of the key published academic research. Familiarize yourself with opportunities outside of your particular interests (such as the New Venture Challenge). The Booth MBA is a transformative experience; through your application, demonstrate to the admissions team that you have a plan, but that you are open to the possibilities and avenues that a Chicago MBA will provide. Show the Committee that you recognize the importance of a well-rounded MBA education, and that you appreciate the value of the flexible curriculum structure.



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Tip #4 - The interview

Chicago Booth extensively uses its network of staff, current students, and alumni to conduct admissions interviews throughout the year, all over the world. Although the interview receives equal weight in the overall application, regardless of who is conducting the interview, you should tailor your interview strategy accordingly. Typically, alumni and current students have a very different perception of how a candidate might fit in at Chicago Booth (using their own personal experience and background), and can often be much more critical evaluators than admissions staff. Admissions staff on the other hand will have a better sense for how the class is already shaping up, and how your unique experience could contribute to the current intake. Use the interview to highlight areas of your personal and professional life that are not already represented in your application. Be especially careful of “walking” your interviewer through your resume. They have already looked at your resume, and are looking to glean much more information from you than your professional history timeline. The purpose of the interview is to establish a connection with the person across the table, and convince them of why you are a good “fit” with Chicago Booth.

Tip #5 - Tackling the GMAT

So, you did not score as highly as you would have liked on the GMAT. Chicago Booth has moved away from requiring a specific GMAT score in order to apply, which means that the admissions committee is looking for more than just data points in your file. However, the reality is that the GMAT is a factor in your application (the current average is 731), and the school attracts large numbers of applicants with very strong quant scores, typically well above the 80%. It is important that the admissions committee understand your ability to keep up with the academic environment at Chicago Booth. In your application, you need to address a less than stellar GMAT score by highlighting areas that specifically show your intellectual capability. There may be specific courses from your undergrad transcript in calculus or statistics that show your ability with numbers. Maybe you have a publication to your name, or your recommender can speak to your analytical skills and use of data-heavy spreadsheets. The CFA is another great way to show your quant skills, or you can show your determination and self awareness by signing up for a suitable online course.

Tip #6: Get to know Booth and define how you will be able to contribute

The written application is the final piece of the puzzle. There are so many steps that lead up to that “submit” button. Admissions want to know that you are going to be more than a body in a lecture room. Part of what makes Chicago Booth such a thriving academic environment is the diversity of students in each of the MBA programs. This diversity is what drives critical thinking and pushes students into collaboration instead of competition. They want people who will get up and get involved, lead the charge. And beyond the classroom they are looking for engagement and interaction. So do some research on the clubs and activities that would be of interest to you, and where possible reach out to students or alumni who themselves were actively part of a particular club to better understand the opportunities available to you. When possible, you should try to visit campus and/or attend admissions events. It is important to see the programs in action and to see interaction between current students, faculty, and staff. Use all of the information at hand to truly comprehend your “fit” at Chicago Booth and show Admissions not only who you are but what you will contribute to the community as a current student and an alumnus.



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Tip #7 - Teamwork is important

The academic culture at Chicago Booth encourages innovative thinking, challenging the status quo, and working together to achieve results. Although your application should, of course, highlight your personal achievements and accomplishments, the admissions committee will also be looking for examples of how you build relationships, how you lead, and how you motivate people. The old stereotype of Chicago Booth is of an individualistic and highly competitive environment. But with the new facilities and grade non-disclosure, there is now a premium placed on your ability to work with others.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

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